

Instead of supersonic speed, the way forward for passenger airliners turned out to lie in size and economy. Even in the 1960s, the widespread adoption of jet airliners brought downward pressure on seat prices. More people were traveling further than ever before, partly because it had become quicker, easier, and more pleasant to fly, but also because it was becoming cheaper.

Wide-bodied jets

The entry of the wide-bodied Boeing 747s into service in 1970 carried this process to a new level. The message of the 747's success was that air travel was going to be mass travel. Airports had to reinforce runways and expand passenger and baggage handling facilities, initially

swamped by 300 or 400 people disgorging at once from a single aircraft. In-flight caterers had to adjust to supplying their fare in previously undreamed of quantities. Hotels had to be built to cope with the rising tide of travelers.



The 747 represented no great technological breakthrough, just better engines and business daring. Other widebodies inevitably came in its wake as rival manufacturers sought to break Boeing's increasing domination of the market. They could not challenge the giant 747 head-on, but sought out a market share among airlines for which the 747 was just too big. McDonnell Douglas came up with the DC-10, Lockheed produced the TriStar, and a new consortium of European manufacturers, Airbus Industrie, built the Airbus A300. The DC-10 and TriStar were

SPACIOUS INTERIOR

The spacious interior of a 747 is a familiar sight today, but when the airliner was first brought into service it astonished passengers used to narrow cabins with a single aisle.

